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A CHAPTER OF CONDENSED HISTORY.

THE story of Japan, so old and yet so new, acquires new interest daily. In the history of the world no such chapter has heretofore been unfolded; and when we shall have discovered something of the motives which underlie the curious revolution in the Land of the Sun, we may, supplementing the bare record of facts with the political philosophy of the Empire, bequeath to other times a part of the history of these times which shall be entirely unique. Such an air of mysterious antiquity veils the antecedents of the Empire of Japan—so dim are the traditions of its early beginnings—that the appearance of an important Embassy in the chief cities of a nation undreamed of when Japan was hoary with age, is one of those odd surprises in the movements of the human race which puzzle and startle the most careless observers. The origin of the barbarous tribes of the continents of Asia and Africa is, to be sure, quite as vague and remote as that of the Japanese nation; but even the dim oral traditions of the aborigines of our own continent, and the fabulous, romantic legends of the ancient Aztecs, are not more obscure than the early historic reminiscences of this great people, which has, for untold centuries, possessed a positive form of civilization, a symmetrical system of government, a national religion, and has practiced arts and sciences which seem to be old as the days of Tubal-Cain and Enos. A meeting of the representatives of the youngest and the oldest nations of the earth, on a continent which had not even been discovered at the time when European voyagers gave to the world their reports of observations on Japan, is certainly an event of no ordinary character.

Other visitors, other Embassadors from Japan, have been seen in San Francisco and Washington, before now; but none, possibly, have brought with them that peculiar significance which this Embassy, emerging from Japan at the close of a great peaceful revolution, bears to us. To understand the significance of current events, and to apprehend what part the United States has in the present phenomenal condition of her transpacific neighbors, it is necessary to

writers, even on first principles. Each seems to have a theory or a hobby of his own. The critics do not agree in their doctrines, nor the artists in their methods. I have, at last, come to the resolution to content myself with admiring and enjoying such works of Art as I find myself capable of appreciating, without perplexing myself with the interminable disputes of rival schools and opposing philosophers."

"It is the most comfortable plan," said Pictor; "and yet the diversity in Art-doctrine does not prove that there is no such thing as a true Art-philosophy, any more than the thousand creeds of Christendom prove that there is no Christian truth. As there is some element of truth in all the creeds, so I think that each of the Art-sects has a mission. The complete truth of Art may be likened to a great circle—too great for any one mind to grasp. Each earnest thinker and teacher seizes upon a segment,

and sees the particular truth that is in it so clearly, feels its beauty so deeply, that it somewhat obscures his vision for other related truths, and blunts his feeling for other kinds of beauty. So with method. Nearly every eminent painter has some modes of working (some 'knacks,' if you will) that are peculiar to himself. If he produces remarkable effects in this way, those who don't understand the method are apt to call it 'a trick.' Why, one of your Art-critics, not long ago, charged me with resorting to 'a cheap labor-saving trick,' because I produced the *effect* of foliage without any attempt to draw or imitate it in detail."

"That fellow's idea of the proper way to render foliage," said Mæcenæ, "was probably derived from studies of leaves and flowers on patterns of calico and wall-paper."

"Nevertheless," said Pictor, "it is the privilege of every American to be a critic."

HONA MARIA.

SOUTHWARD from the quaint town of Santa Barbara, beyond the Santa Barbara Bay—with its high-arching isles, summery winds, and the softened splendor of semi-tropical skies—five leagues out in the ocean, the island of San Nicolas lifts its brown, rugged outline from the surging waters. Hidden from the main-land by Santa Cruz, an island of greater magnitude, the sun seems to rise from the purpled rim of the waters, and to set where the golden seas meet the horizon of the golden skies. The waves wash far up the sloping, sandy shore, and, receding, leave bright shells, tangled kelp, and smooth, wave-polished stones. The seals sun themselves on the crystallized rocks, and gaze at the intruder with almost human eyes. The sea-wasps shake

their delicate wings in the bright atmosphere; and strange birds call from the high branches of unfamiliar trees. Deep pools lie hidden in lonely gorges, and fold their secrets forever in their dark bosoms. The wild dogs bark from the shelving rocks, and, with uncanny faces, dart into the close ravine.

Years and years ago, ere the energies of the White settlers had made their impress upon the wilderness along the Pacific shore, a tribe of Indians existed on this now desolate isle. Of what they thought, suffered, hoped, or accomplished, we have only scanty tradition. Now and then a pirate's craft anchored along the quiet shore, and, departing, told no tale. Sometimes the friendly voice of the Mission Fathers stole across the calm bay; and the shadow of the Cross, plant-

ed in the wilderness, threw its benign influence even over these undeveloped children of the sun. But the Fathers sleep, and left no record.

Thirty-six years ago the Famine found this isolated band, and clutched them with its gaunt, relentless hand. The parched earth refused her sustenance; the trees stood bare and leafless in the hot wind; the streams ran dry, and the rocks glittered white and salt under the fervid sun. The wild game famished and died; and the fierce preyed upon each other. With pitying horror, these human beings stared into each other's faces, and, with stoical fortitude, crawled away to die alone. Whether the Mission Fathers learned of their distress, or whether urged by other motives, is not known; but they fitted out a boat, which sailed to San Nicolas and brought away the survivors—eighteen, in all. As the rescued islanders were brought down to the shore where the boat was anchored, one of the women—who afterward gave her name as Hona Maria—darted away, over the sandy shore, over rough rocks, through tangled ravines, with savage eagerness, to bring her only child, which, by some oversight, had been left behind. They waited for her re-appearance—they waited long. The skies darkened; the winds arose and tossed the unsteady boat from her frail anchorage, and the reluctant Captain was compelled to put out to sea; and Hona Maria was left alone on that desolate, sea-walled isle.

The thick fog shut down over the ocean, and the heavy swell of the waves tossed the boat rapidly toward the mainland. The rescued Indians were kindly cared for by the humane people of Santa Barbara; but, either from past suffering or the unaccustomed influences of civilization, they died, or dispersed to wilder surroundings. The boat was wrecked, preventing another expedition to the islands, and for years was not replaced. Hona Maria was supposed to have died, and no heart turned to the lonely island.

Eighteen solitary years had passed. White faces peered over the rocky battlement of mountains, and browned under the California sun. Avenues of communication and commerce were opened, and the mysteries of the Golden State were penetrated. Captain Nidever, a resident of Santa Barbara, fitted a schooner at Monterey, and, in one of his cruises, anchored at the tragic island of San Nicolas. In wandering over the island, he found traces of human life: ashes yet warm—a foot-print in the soil. But, again, the storm beat down upon the shore, and compelled the small crew to put out to sea. With clear skies and becalmed seas they returned. Again, the smoldering fire—the trace in the sand; and after a short search, to their amazement, Hona Maria herself—the Hermit Monarch of this lonely isle! Without the least sign of surprise she gazed, for the first time in eighteen years, upon human faces. In unintelligible language, but with expressive, savage gestures, she made them understand that the dogs killed her child. This was the burden of her limited expressions—this longing for human sympathy amid her tragic desolation—bursting the bondage of unintelligible language, and making the grand sorrow of her savage heart known and felt.

A rude hut, constructed of interlaced branches, sticks, and leaves, constituted her shelter. A fantastic robe of gayly feathered bird-skins, neatly dressed and adroitly stitched with fine tendons, by the aid of needles manufactured from fish-bones, covered her dusky limbs, and another of brighter hues was ready for time of need, or possibly reserved for her solitary festivals. Many rude treasures, collected during her hermitage, were transferred to the boat, and afterward landed at Santa Barbara. With astonishment she beheld the mainland. Her rapid glance took in the coast and the placid valley, girdled by the rugged mountains, sloping to the

bay. From the narrow limits of her island-home, the sea only was vast, stretching away beyond the range of vision. The boundless view of land presented a new and strange geographical development to her uneducated mind. A "solitary horseman" galloping along the smooth beach caused her ecstasies of delight, which she expressed in long, wild peals of laughter and fantastic dances. A team with oxen completed her amusement. She observed the unfamiliar actions of people and animals with child-like pleasure, yet never forgot her lost child, nor the horrible manner of its death. She was proud of the attention she received, pleased with gifts and kindness, like a child in a new creation. She spoke a dialect entirely different from the native Spanish or Indians of the Santa Barbara region. A short time previous to her death, which occurred six months after her departure from her native island, an

Indian woman was found who could interpret her strange tongue. She had not much to tell. A life more colorless, devoid of imagery or experience, it is impossible to conceive. The effect of long seclusion, upon her mind so crude and undeveloped, can not be conjectured. In her solitary abode she knew the ways of the birds of the air and fishes of the sea, and fashioned nets to capture them, which, with seals and roots, furnished her sustenance.

Large sums of money were refused by Captain Nidever for the possession of the woman, as an attractive addition to a museum; but she was kindly guarded at his private residence, and in 1853 she passed to the spirit-land. The Bishop took possession of her ingeniously manufactured robes, and carried them to Rome.

Hona Maria sleeps on the quiet hill-side; and her strange fate, hitherto, has been a dim tradition.

DISSEVERED.

The Rose renews her sensuous bloom,
The Lily gems the garden-walk,
The Pinks above the borders loom,
I hear the Bluebird's twittered talk.

The sunlight gilds the poplar-leaves,
And green and gold the meadows glow,
His wood-side net the spider weaves,
And hums the blithe bee to and fro.

O, once-beloved sounds and sights!
That drift my moody vision by,
Which her dear presence made delights,
And which her absence makes a lie;

In vain upon my sense you press:
I know not what the Bluebird said;
I can not half your meanings guess:
Your true interpreter is dead.

No more the Rose her perfume gives;
The Lily's pale with grief and scorn;
The Pink in scentless beauty lives:
The world of incense is forlorn!